

Chapter 161-1

Liang Shi's gaze happened to meet Zhao Xuning's.

Almost instantly, Liang Shi knew what Zhao Xuning was thinking.

The two of them had the same thought.

However, Feng Xian frowned and said: "Is that even possible? It was already a stillborn—what would be the point of stealing it? Besides, I never heard that Shi'an Hospital lost a child during those days."

"Was it abandoned because it died young?" Feng Xian continued to speculate.

Zhao Xuning slowly shook her head: "Even if it died young, the probability of abandonment is very low."

Feng Xian was quite intelligent. Her gaze swept back and forth between Zhao Xuning and Liang Shi, then she said: "Do you already know who it is?"

Liang Shi slowly shook her head, her voice very soft: "Still not certain."

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Regardless of anything else, it was a great blessing that Gu Xingyue and Feng Xian could reunite.

Both had been alone and lonely—now they could depend on each other.

On the way home, Liang Shi and Zhao Xuning felt somewhat heavy-hearted. The topic mentioned earlier was quite sensitive, and neither wanted to say more.

This created a silent atmosphere.

Liang Shi couldn't stand it and turned on a song.

It happened to be an old Cantonese love song.

Outside, the trees were still bare. The harsh winter in Haizhou City had not yet passed.

This winter seemed particularly long.

Inside the car, the love song was sung with heartbreaking emotion. The dim yellow streetlights refracted through the car windows, casting gentle light on both their faces.

After a long while, Zhao Xuning said: "Shi'an Hospital has shares from the Shen family."

Liang Shi happened to swallow her saliva, and the gulping sound was quite jarring in the quiet atmosphere.

"So what?" The moment Liang Shi asked, she realized her tone was a bit harsh. She lightly pressed her lips together. "Sorry."

"It's fine." Zhao Xuning said, "Just telling you. Don't overthink it."

Liang Shi: "....."

Zhao Xuning really was someone who didn't like to meddle in others' affairs.

All the way until they got home, she didn't bring up this matter again.

Liang Shi suspected that if Feng Xian hadn't once been Zhao Xuning's benefactor and teacher, Zhao Xuning probably wouldn't have bothered to do the DNA comparison between Feng Xian and Gu Xingyue.

Even though Zhao Xuning said not to overthink it, the logic already laid out before her made it impossible not to.

It was just that there was nothing to use for a DNA comparison.

Liang Shi even dreamed about this matter at night.

But it wasn't exactly a pleasant dream. When acknowledging kinship with the Shen family, she was extremely frightened.

She woke up startled in the middle of the night. After getting up to pour half a glass of water in the kitchen, she couldn't fall back asleep.

Lately, she often found herself in this state—groggy and living through her days in low spirits.

She would suddenly feel sad in bustling crowds, and feel lonely when staying home alone.

She kept thinking about Xu Qingzhu. One night she even buried herself under the covers and cried, and the next day her eyes were swollen beyond recognition.

The day she received Xu Qingzhu's call happened to be the night before she had to go for an audition.

To make sure she would be in good shape, she had taken melatonin the night before.

So she had a rare, deep sleep.

But after being woken by the phone call, she didn't feel irritated. Instead, her heart ached in waves.

After hanging up, she tried to fall asleep again but couldn't sleep well no matter what.

The next day when she went to the audition, she wasn't in the best condition.

This was a pretty good opportunity for a newcomer. The agent had always been measured in arranging these things, progressing step by step, and had even designed a persona and marketing route for her.

Having Liang Shi take the gentle yet commanding big sister¹ route would fit the movie better.

This time, the director was one of the better ones in China for light comedy films, and the role Liang Shi was auditioning for was the only tearjerker in the light comedy.

Because her character would die in the end.

Liang Shi didn't think she couldn't act it. On the contrary, she was very professional.

It was just that not sleeping well the night before had affected her a little. She hadn't reached her best state, and there were many competitors auditioning alongside her, all showcasing their talents. As a newcomer in this field, she wasn't among the top contenders.

But she had already done her best.

Coming out of the audition venue with her agent, the agent had even bought two ice cream cones. On such a cold day, the two of them stood in a corner downstairs eating ice cream.

Liang Shi teased her: "Is it because my performance made your heart go cold?"

The agent: "....."

The agent didn't respond to her cold joke². She just flipped through Liang Shi's schedule and told her about this week's arrangements.

Making reasonable use of all her time.

Liang Shi readily accepted.

The days that followed flew by. The agent didn't let Liang Shi idle at all.

Appearing in magazines that weren't very popular to get exposure, auditioning at different production crews, and going on some lukewarm variety shows as a guest.

Until the day "Happy Tropic" aired.

Unexpectedly, the production team actually used Liang Shi's red outfit look and fan dance as a gimmick.

They especially used a 20-second video, edited out Liang Shi's solo cut, and bought a hot search. The hashtag was called #The Sister in Red Who Amazed Netizens is Back#

A super long hashtag.

Netizens below unanimously commented: 【Yang Shuyan?】

Yang Shuyan's red outfit look in that movie was indeed very popular. The well-known "red outfit kill" that everyone knew came from her.

It wasn't even promoted by fans—it was voted on by passersby.

But when they clicked into the hashtag, they found it was Liang Shi.

The comment section immediately exploded into chaos.

Footnotes:

¹ **Gentle yet commanding big sister (溫柔禦姐):** "禦姐" (yù jiě) is a term derived from Japanese ("onee-san") referring to a mature, elegant, and often slightly domineering older sister type. Combined with "gentle," it describes a persona that is both warm and sophisticated with a commanding presence.

² **Cold joke (冷笑話):** A Chinese term for a "cold joke" or "dry humor"—a pun or joke that's so bad or unfunny that it makes people feel "cold" rather than amused. Here, Liang Shi made a pun connecting "cold" (from the ice cream) with her performance making the agent's "heart go cold" (disappointed).

Chapter 161-2

【Ugh, I thought it was Yang Shuyan. Is this D-list celebrity¹ trying to ride on the hype too?】

【The person above is wrong. I checked and she only has a minor role in an upcoming drama. Calling her D-list is already giving her too much credit.】

【Is this photo even that good-looking? Why can't I see it?】

【Honestly, I really don't think she's good-looking. That red outfit look from before was also just average. She's like eight hundred Zhao Yings away from Yang Shuyan.】

【Hey, if you want to talk, just talk. Why drag others down to lift someone up?²】

【.....】

Almost everyone had only seen the photos released by the production team.

It wasn't stunning at all—it wasn't even as good as the passerby perspective photos on Weibo before.

With filters applied, her looks dropped drastically. Plus, the outfit had no memorable features, making people have no desire to watch.

But Liang Shi wasn't affected. She only posted a promotional Weibo post at her agent's request and didn't pay any more attention. Then that evening, she found Zhao Xuning watching TV, and it happened to be the variety show she was on.

Liang Shi: "?"

"Let's not watch this," Liang Shi said.

Zhao Xuning was puzzled: "Why?"

"It's not good," Liang Shi said.

She really didn't want to die of embarrassment in front of Zhao Xuning.

And she was genuinely afraid that someone like Zhao Xuning—a top student who never took the conventional path—would see her doing fan dancing and decide she needed to buy a fan and learn it too.

"I think it's quite good," Zhao Xuning said. "I watch it every week."

Liang Shi: "....."

"You really don't look like someone who'd enjoy watching this kind of variety show." Liang Shi opened the fridge, took out two cans of cold beer, and tossed one over to her.

Zhao Xuning caught it, popped it open with a click, then shrugged lightly. "Shen Hui used to like watching it."

So she watched along.

Most of the time, Shen Hui watched the variety show while she watched Shen Hui. When bored, she'd play with her hair, or hold her in her arms and feed her food.

Back then, Shen Hui always complained, "This is exactly how you've been fattening me up!"

She would pinch Shen Hui's waist and say, "I like it."

And then greedily bury her face in Shen Hui's neck, kissing the fresh scent of her hair tips like sniffing a cat.

Shen Hui had nestled in her arms watching many episodes of this show, so she had also developed the habit of watching it.

When two people stayed together for a long time, they really did become similar in certain ways.

Just like before, Zhao Xuning didn't like spicy food, but after being with Shen Hui, she could handle spicy food.

Zhao Xuning also didn't like exercising, but Shen Hui did—running, swimming, crunches, Pilates, yoga—so Zhao Xuning had trained with her too.

The most ridiculous thing was that Zhao Xuning, someone with completely uncoordinated limbs, had even learned street dance with Shen Hui.

Back then, she often said that when Shen Hui danced, it was beautiful, but when she danced, it was like a little demon coming for your life³.

Even after they separated, Zhao Xuning would watch this variety show every week whenever she had time.

Even when she was exhausted, she would keep this variety show on as background noise.

Before Liang Shi spoke up, she really hadn't expected Liang Shi to be on this show.

Liang Shi simply gave up and sat next to her to watch together.

The opening featured a senior actor from their company singing a love song duet with the show's host.

The pitch wasn't great, but the vocal tone was nice.

When Liang Shi's dance segment came on, after watching it, Zhao Xuning took a sip of beer and gave a rare compliment: "Not bad."

Meanwhile on Weibo, the clip of her dancing had made it to the hot search, and the public opinion had completely shifted.

Before the broadcast, she had been criticized as ugly because of the photos and solo promotional images released by the production team. Now the comment section was full of praise.

【This is something I can watch for free?】

【Did you all look carefully? At the 22-second mark when she raises her arm, she has abs!】

【Saw it, screenshotted it! Image.jpg】

【It's mainly her eyes though. Wuwuwu I instantly got her beauty!】

【I just want to ask—you stupid show, are you deliberately sabotaging yourselves?!】

【Yes yes yes! After watching the video and then looking at the photos, I want to kill the production team.】

【.....】

Liang Shi's Weibo followers grew extremely fast—she gained 100,000 followers in less than an hour.

At the same time, on the other side of the city, Xu Qingzhu had returned home and was curled up on the sofa, spacing out.

Her phone beside her buzzed. It was a message from Sally.

Sally: 【...Your Liang Shi is too beautiful.】

Sally: 【Is there a solo fancam? I have a friend who wants to see it.】

Xu Qingzhu: 【?】

She had no idea what Sally was talking about, so Sally forwarded her a Weibo post.

After Liang Shi left, Xu Qingzhu rarely opened Weibo.

Especially her side account.

She was afraid that after seeing her news, she wouldn't be able to resist contacting her. Even more afraid that after seeing her updates, she wouldn't dare to contact her.

So she simply avoided it altogether.

When she opened it now, she saw the video of Liang Shi dancing in red. On stage, she was different from when acting—every movement was perfect. Even though there weren't many shots of her, whenever the camera panned to her, she seemed to radiate her own light.

Footnotes:

¹ **D-list celebrity (十八線):** Literally "eighteenth-tier," this is Chinese internet slang for extremely minor or unknown celebrities. The entertainment industry hierarchy is often described in "tiers" (線), with first-tier being the most famous. "Eighteenth-tier" essentially means someone with virtually no fame.

² **Drag others down to lift someone up (拉踩):** A common Chinese internet term meaning to criticize or put down one person/thing in order to praise another. It's considered poor behavior in fan communities.

³ **Little demon coming for your life (小鬼索命):** A humorous Chinese expression meaning something is so bad or chaotic it's like a vengeful spirit has come to claim your soul. Here it's used self-deprecatingly to describe terrible dancing.

Chapter 161-3

After watching it, Xu Qingzhu looped it twice more, then went back to look at the comments.

Almost all of them were showering Liang Shi with praise¹.

Xu Qingzhu scrolled for a long time but couldn't reach the bottom—there were too many.

It seemed like Liang Shi had suddenly become famous.

Everyone's discussions about her were also very active.

Xu Qingzhu browsed through her Weibo and saw her replying to fans in the comments². Her responses were all very gentle.

However, her verification had changed. It used to just be "Actress Liang Shi."

Now it was changed to "Huayi Entertainment Contracted Actress Liang Shi."

Huayi Entertainment...

Xu Qingzhu looked through the contracts on her computer. The company she and Lu Jiayi had acquired... was this one.

Moreover, she had a meeting with Huayi's upper management tomorrow and would also be meeting some of Huayi's main artists.

Of course, that didn't include newcomers like Liang Shi.

Xu Qingzhu browsed Weibo for a long time, then finally let out a soft breath.

The familiar feeling of nausea hit her again. She ran to the bathroom, and after throwing up, her face was pale. Leaning against the sink, she finally made a decision—she had to let her know.

—Even without love, she could use Liang Shi's sense of morality and responsibility to keep her.

Xu Qingzhu without Liang Shi wasn't happy at all.

Even if it was forced or stolen, there would still be brief moments of happiness.

Xu Qingzhu took out her phone and sent a message to Huayi's upper management: 【I thought that artist Liang Shi on today's show was pretty good. Have her come to my office at 10 AM tomorrow. I have a good drama I can get her into, but she needs to audition.】

This message sounded very much like she wanted to make Liang Shi submit to unspoken rules³.

Huayi's upper management was also confused. Was the new CEO this... direct?

The executive looked at the message and finally polished it a bit before sending it to Liang Shi's agent: 【Liang Shi is lucky. A big shot has taken a liking to her and wants her to play the female lead in their next production. Have her meet the investor tomorrow. This has to work out.】

After reading it, the agent asked for the time and location, then sent Liang Shi a simple and clear message.

【Be downstairs waiting for me at 9:50 AM tomorrow. I'll take you to meet the investor.】

Liang Shi was puzzled: 【Not the director?】

Agent: 【The investor. They can get you into the production with funding.】

Liang Shi stared at her phone with a grave expression. Zhao Xuning asked: "What's wrong?"

Liang Shi frowned and sighed: "It seems like someone wants to use unspoken rules on me."

Zhao Xuning: "?"

Footnotes:

¹ **Showering with praise (吹彩虹屁)**: Literally "blowing rainbow farts," this is Chinese internet slang for excessively praising someone, usually a celebrity or idol. It refers to fans' enthusiastic compliments that are so over-the-top they're compared to colorful, flowery flattery.

² **Replying to fans (翻牌子)**: Literally "flipping name plates," this term originates from ancient Chinese imperial courts where the emperor would flip over a concubine's name plate to select her for the night. In modern usage, it refers to celebrities responding to or acknowledging fan comments on social media—being "chosen" by the celebrity feels like a special honor.

³ **Unspoken rules (潜規則)**: A term referring to the hidden, unofficial rules in various industries, particularly the entertainment industry, where sexual favors are exchanged for career opportunities. It's a well-known phenomenon in Chinese showbiz and is generally viewed very negatively.